

Defender Sheet

Bridge Habit Map

AUCTION

Listen & anticipate

- ☐ Think during every bid — don't wait for your turn
- ☐ Convert each bid into shape + HCP for the bidder
- ☐ Note what's asked vs not asked (missing major = no 4-card major)
- ☐ Spot the system tools in play (Stayman, transfers, NMF, 4SF, cues)

Build the picture

- ☐ Form a mental shape-pattern for at least one opponent
- ☐ Start from minimum length promised — refine as bids land
- ☐ Add visible HCP, subtract from 40 → partner's range

Lead prep (if you'll be on lead)

- ☐ Pick a tentative opening lead during the auction, not after
- ☐ Watch for lead-directing double opportunities on artificial bids

DEFENSE PLAN

Discipline

- ☐ Don't rush, don't get rushed — especially trick 1
- ☐ Have a reason for what you do

Count the points

- ☐ Add declarer + dummy HCP, subtract from 40
- ☐ Divide missing points using the auction
- ☐ If dummy is strong, give declarer minimum for their bid

Picture the unseen hands

Count declarer's tricks

- ☐ Build a hand-pattern for declarer (e.g. 3-5-3-2)
- ☐ Memorise your hand + dummy before playing
- ☐ Count declarer's distribution, HCP, and tricks
- ☐ No side-suit tricks for you? Look to trump (overruff, uppercut, promotion)

Identify the winning defense

- ☐ Which 2–3 declarer hand-patterns let you beat the contract?
- ☐ What suit does declarer fear?

Active or passive (binary)

- ☐ Long-suit declarer with a source of tricks → ACTIVE
- ☐ Balanced declarer, no obvious source → PASSIVE (don't break suits)
- ☐ Don't grab aces prematurely — aces capture kings

Opening lead (if on lead)

- ☐ Avoid suits opponents bid; favour unbid suits
- ☐ vs NT: 4th best from longest, or top of sequence
- ☐ vs suit: K from AK, top of doubleton; don't underlead an ace
- ☐ Trump lead if auction suggests a cross-ruff; not vs misfit
- ☐ Lead partner's bid suit unless you have a clear reason not to

Watch & remember

- ☐ Commit the first few cards from partner + declarer to memory
- ☐ Decide now which spot cards in which suits will matter